DESIGN THINKING JOURNEY

Where we are, what we know, and what comes next

Mass-Affluent Wealth Advice - working guide for the team

CURRENT STATUS

WE ARE HERE

1 - Understand

Research preparation is strong. The team still needs to agree on the target customer, market and problem to solve.

Do not lock the solution yet.

Working status - 11.10.2026

The full process - and our current position

Each phase reduces uncertainty. We only move forward when the previous decision is clear enough to test.



The decision logic

Who + what problem? → **Why does it happen?** → **Which idea?** → **Does it help?** → **Is it worth piloting?**

Problem first -> evidence second -> solution third.

Innovation School process: Understand -> Empathize & Synthesize -> Ideate -> Prototype & Test -> Business Case & Pitch.

What we already know before the workshop

We have enough research to start well - but not enough customer evidence to declare the final problem.

What we learned

- Mass affluent is a customer group; Premium is a service proposition.
- Some banks already offer pieces of the journey: advice, digital investing, education, human support and robo-advice.
- The opportunity may be in how those pieces are combined and delivered - not necessarily a brand-new platform.

What the expert suggests

- Manual advice is difficult to scale for lower investment amounts.
- Education, simpler tools and assisted digital journeys may reduce friction.
- Banker time is more valuable when spent explaining why a proposal fits, not on paperwork.

What is still unknown

- Which market and exact mass-affluent subgroup should be our focus?
- Where does that customer actually struggle in a recent real journey?
- Which problem is important enough to solve first - and how often does it occur?

Working framing: more valuable than generic retail guidance, but cheaper and more scalable than full private banking.

Current evidence comes from desk research, public service examples and an internal expert interview; customer validation still needs to happen.

03 - CURRENT PHASE

Phase 1 - Understand

Goal: agree what problem space we are actually investigating before discussing solutions.

WE ARE HERE

What we need to agree

- Market / country.
- Specific customer subgroup.
- What service they receive today.
- Which moment in the journey is worth investigating.
- What we know vs. what we are only assuming.

Questions to work through

- What is the customer trying to achieve?
- Where do they become uncertain, stop, repeat information or seek help elsewhere?
- What does the current RBI journey already solve?
- Which missing facts would change our view?

Exit gate

- One provisional target customer.
- One clearly described problem area.
- A current-journey map with evidence labels.
- A short list of questions to validate in the next phase.

Do NOT exit this phase with “we will build an AI adviser.” Exit with “this customer appears to struggle here, and this is what we need to verify.”

04 - NEXT PHASE

Phase 2 - Empathize & Synthesize

Goal: replace assumptions with evidence from actual experiences, then define the problem precisely.

What we will do

- Talk to customers where possible and include bankers / experts.
- Ask about a recent real experience, not hypothetical preferences.
- Listen for moments of confusion, delay, workarounds, mistrust and repetition.
- Capture exact observations separately from our interpretation.

What we try to learn

- What triggered the financial decision?
- Where did the customer look for help?
- Where did they become unsure or stop?
- What did human support add?
- What happened after the recommendation / investment?

Exit gate

- 2-3 evidence-backed insights.
- One focused problem statement.
- One “How might we...?” question that leaves room for several solutions.
- Agreement that the problem is worth exploring.

Example structure: [Customer] needs [outcome] when [situation], because [evidence-backed difficulty], leading to [consequence].

Phase 3 - Ideate

This is where we choose a solution direction - after the problem has been validated well enough.

Generate alternatives

- Better explanation of the existing proposal.
- Guided digital investment journey.
- Education / learning content.
- Human handover with context.
- Wealth health check or goal review.
- AI assistant only if the problem justifies it.

Compare ideas

- Customer relevance.
- Expected benefit.
- Feasibility and integration effort.
- Scalability and cost.
- Regulatory / advisory responsibility.
- What already exists today.

Exit gate

- 2-3 concepts compared fairly.
- One concept selected for testing.
- The biggest assumption written explicitly.
- The smallest test that could prove us wrong.

Important: choose the idea because it addresses the validated problem - not because the technology is attractive.

Phase 4 - Prototype & Test

Goal: test the riskiest assumption before anyone spends time building a full solution.

Build only enough to learn

- Paper or clickable mock screens.
- One-page explanation.
- Role-play of adviser handover.
- Mock chatbot conversation.
- Simple goal-review dashboard.

Observe behavior

- Give the user a concrete task.
- Ask them to explain what they understood.
- Record where they hesitate or misinterpret.
- Do not rely only on “Would you use this?”
- Change the prototype based on what happened.

Exit gate

- A tested assumption.
- Observed evidence - including failures.
- A revised concept or decision to change direction.
- Clear remaining uncertainty for a pilot.

A good prototype is not impressive. It is cheap, specific and capable of teaching us something important.

Phase 5 - Business Case & Pitch

Goal: explain customer value, bank value, delivery implications and the next sensible experiment.

Customer value

- Better understanding of fit, risk and cost.
- Less friction and repetition.
- Help available at the right moment.
- A useful next action - even when no product is sold.
- Clearer follow-up and goal review.

Bank / operational value

- Less adviser administration.
- More scalable service.
- Higher completion or fewer avoidable repeat contacts.
- Stronger relationship and possible asset retention.
- Better use of existing capabilities.

Final ask

- What should we pilot?
- With which customers?
- Who needs to own it?
- What will it cost?
- What measures tell us whether to continue, change or stop?

Aim for permission to run a credible pilot - not permission to build a full platform.

Our working status - what gets filled in as we learn

Use this as the one-page mental model for the workshop. Each blank gets filled only when evidence supports it.

Item	Status	What happens next
Target market / country	OPEN	Agree in Understand
Target customer subgroup	OPEN	Agree in Understand
Current journey / services	PARTIAL	Map and verify in Understand
Main pain point	HYPOTHESIS	Validate in Empathize
Evidence / customer insight	MISSING	Collect in Empathize
How might we question	MISSING	Write after synthesis
Chosen solution direction	NOT YET	Choose in Ideate
Prototype learning	NOT YET	Create in Prototype & Test
Business case / pilot ask	NOT YET	Build last

Right now our job is simple: define the problem well enough that the next phase can challenge it with real evidence.